ART TAKES FLIGHT:

The Soul and Structure of Mumbai Airport's Terminal 2

When Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport's (CSMIA) Terminal 2 opened on February 12, 2014, it didn't just create infrastructure — it created an experience. Behind its peacock-inspired architecture lies one of the world's largest public art collections, transforming a global gateway into a celebration of India's living heritage and creative future.



For most global travellers, an airport is a pause in motion — a passage between two places. For Mumbai, Terminal 2 (T2) at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport is a destination in itself: a stunning blend of design, scale and soul.

Spanning 4.7 million square feet and handling up to 55 million passengers annually, T2 stands among the world's most distinctive terminals.

Designed by New York's Skidmore, Owings & Merrill (SOM), its architecture draws inspiration from the peacock, India's national bird—with feather motifs subtly reflected in rooflines, columns and lighting. The 11-acre roof, supported by 30 mega-columns, creates a vast, fluid interior. Overhead, 5,698 dichroic lenses and 272 skylights flood the space with prismatic light, turning structure into spectacle.

The Birth of a Cultural Landmark

When India opened its airport sector to private participation in 2006, few imagined a gateway that would also become a gallery. The vision for T2 was to make Mumbai's airport not just efficient, but evocative — not just functional, but emotional.

Stretching 3.2 km, the collection features over 5,500 artefacts and 100+ artworks, making it one of the world's largest public art initiatives.

Curated by Rajeev Sethi, India's pioneering scenographer, the project brings together artisans from across India— from Kanchipuram weavers to West Bengal's terracotta sculptors, Tanjore painters to Kashmiri woodcarvers. Ancient traditions meet modern abstraction; every corridor becomes a canvas of India's creative continuum.

Tune in to the Soul of CSMIA's Terminal 2

The Artbeat of New India Audio Guide App is an immersive audio-visual companion designed to help travellers explore the art treasures displayed across the departure area of T2. Through engaging narration, the app brings to life the fascinating stories behind each artefact — revealing the creativity, effort and inspiration that shaped this unique museum experience within the vibrant setting of an international airport.